Westbrook City Council

~ Special Meeting ~

Date: Monday, March 16, 2026
Time: 7:00 PM
Location: Westbrook High School (Room 114), 125 Stroudwater St. (Hybrid via Zoom)
Video: https://vimeo.com/1174188950
Packet: https://www.westbrookmaine.gov/AgendaCenter/ViewFile/Agenda/_03162026-993

Timestamps below are clickable [0:00]-style links — they jump straight to that moment in the video.

This summary highlights the meeting's key discussions and decisions, with direct quotes and timestamps for verification — it is not a substitute for watching the full meeting. *Summarization necessarily condenses and selects; for complete context, nuance, and anything not covered here, watch the full video at the link above. (Produced by: WestbrookCurrents.com)*

Mayor's Message: Staff Transitions

Finance Department, Assistant City Administrator & Staff Recognitions [2:16]

Discussion Summary

Finance Department: Finance Director Tressina Germani departed after nearly 14 years with the City. Deputy Finance Director Laura King (with the City since 2023, previously a Portland Water District financial analyst for seven years) was appointed Interim Finance Director. With the Tax Collector position also vacant, state statute places that obligation on the Finance Director (see Order 2026-28). The City added the Maine Municipal Association (part-time consulting support, $150/hour) and Robert Half Recruiters & Employment Agency (temporary front-line staffing, ~$35/hour) to its approved vendor list to bridge the gap (Order 2026-30).

Assistant City Administrator: Jenny Franceschi, Director of Planning & Code Enforcement since 2016 and the Maine Association of Planners' 2025 Planner of the Year, was promoted to Assistant City Administrator, continuing part-time as Planning Director until a replacement is hired, with full transition expected around May 1.

City Clerk recognition: Ellis Ledoux received the Certified Clerk of Maine designation from the Maine Town and City Clerks Association after a three-year certification process.

In memoriam: the Mayor noted the recent passing of longtime community volunteer Judith Reedman, who served on numerous city boards and with Rotary.

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken.

Action Items

None.

Public Comment (First)

Non-Municipal Comment & a New Business's Parking Inquiry [11:26]

Discussion Summary

A resident urged support for a letter-writing campaign asking Pope Leo XIV to convene world religious leaders regarding the Iran conflict — not a Westbrook municipal matter, and it drew no Council response or action.

Hayley Bankis, facilities manager for the Center for Autism and Related Disorders (39 Mechanic St., Suite 300, a pediatric therapy provider new to Westbrook), asked about the process for requesting 15-minute parking in front of the building to safely accommodate children with disabilities who cannot safely walk from the current lot. City Administrator Holmes directed her to email the City Clerk's office to coordinate with the relevant departments.

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken.

Action Items

None.

Orders of the Day — Second & Final Reading

Orders 2026-25, -26, -27 — School Bond/Capital-Fund Reallocations & Radio Equipment (Consent) [17:05]

Discussion Summary

All first-read at the Mar. 2, 2026 meeting: reallocating up to $365,000 in unspent Spring 2025 bond proceeds to Canal/Congin School projects; reallocating $385,000 in unused WHS capital funds to security-system and window/door projects; and $678,746.01 for Phase 3 public safety radio equipment — see that meeting's summary for full detail. Moved together; no discussion.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed together by unanimous roll call, 7–0.

Action Items

None.

New Business — Liquor License

Bombay Bistro (3 Vallee Square) [18:45]

Public hearing held.

Discussion Summary

Owned by Blessing Hospitality LLC in partnership with Antonio, Nobel Rugo, and Peter Mutima, managed by James Vazer. Councilor Rairdon flagged a discrepancy between ownership percentages on the state application versus the supplemental ownership form (e.g., one partner listed at 35% on one form and 33% on the other); Antonio explained the differences reflect recent equity changes as new investor-partners joined after the initial application was filed. The Clerk's office agreed to confirm the correct figures with the State before the license takes effect.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved by unanimous roll call, 7–0.

Action Items

None.

Orders of the Day — One Reading Required

Order 2026-28 — Confirming Laura King as Tax Collector [24:56]

Found on page 57 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Discharges former Tax Collector Dena Lebeda from liability for uncollected tax years April 2020 through April 2025 and recommits those balances to Interim Finance Director/Tax Collector Laura King by warrant. Councilor Rairdon noted the difficulty of a new finance director absorbing tax-collector duties without a deputy in place and expressed hope the department returns to full staffing soon.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved by unanimous roll call, 7–0.

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-29 — Amending Order 2026-10 — Additional HVAC Expenditure [28:11]

Found on page 69 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Confirms an additional $1,913.37 emergency expenditure to ABM Mechanical, Inc. for Public Services Facility HVAC repairs, after a leak was discovered in a section of radiant heating during the boiler replacement work (outside the original project scope).

Key Decisions

✓ Approved by unanimous roll call, 7–0.

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-30 — Amending the Annual Vendor List [29:58]

Found on page 72 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Adds Robert Half Recruiters & Employment Agency and the Maine Municipal Association as approved vendors to support Finance Department staffing continuity (see Mayor's Message above). Councilor Chau questioned why no specific dollar figure was before the Council, since vendor-list additions typically avoid the $5,000 approval threshold; Interim Finance Director Laura King and City Administrator Holmes confirmed this is a temporary bridge, not a long-term arrangement, and agreed to keep the Council updated on costs.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved by unanimous roll call, 7–0.

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-31 — Amending Order 2025-135 — City Hall Renovation [36:05]

Found on page 76 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Authorizes an additional $3,100 to Harnois Painting Company for painting work in the City Administrator, Assistant City Administrator, City Clerk, and Deputy City Clerk offices, extending an earlier $8,000 authorization for common-area appearance improvements.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved by unanimous roll call, 7–0.

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-32 — Food Security Grant Program Ordinance (As Amended) [38:32]

Found on page 80 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Amends Code of Ordinances Chapter 33 (Finances) to add a formal, more equitable and transparent Food Security Grant Program for allocating funds to social-service agencies, replacing the City's prior ad hoc approach; adopted as amended by the Finance Committee earlier the same evening.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved by unanimous roll call, 7–0.

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-33 — Uncollectible Ambulance Debt Write-Off Policy [40:31]

Found on page 90 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Allows the Finance Department to write off, on an annual basis, ambulance-billing receivables more than seven years old — the point at which debt-collection industry standards consider medical debt no longer reasonably collectible. The City currently carries more than $1.4 million in unpaid ambulance billing debt dating back to 2003. An initial “true-up” will address the existing backlog, with one additional year written off annually going forward; Councilor Rairdon asked for an annual report of the amount written off, which the administration agreed to provide.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved by unanimous roll call, 7–0.

Action Items

None.

Orders of the Day — Two Readings Required

Order 2026-34 — Community Center Gym Floor Refurbishment [43:53]

Found on page 96 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Accepts a $43,469 donation from the Cornelia Warren Community Association and a $14,000 donation from Paper City Hoops, and authorizes a $57,469 expenditure to New England Sports Floors (Lowell, MA) for the refurbishment. Several councilors thanked both donor organizations.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed first reading, unanimous roll call, 7–0.

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-35 — Credere Associates Task Order No. 8 — Riverwalk North [46:54]

Found on page 100 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Authorizes up to $211,500 to Credere Associates for permitting assistance and design services on the Riverwalk North Brownfields cleanup project, reimbursable through the City's FY2024 $4 million USEPA Brownfields Cleanup Grant — the next phase of the project previewed in the Feb. 23 Annual Project Updates presentation.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed first reading, unanimous roll call, 7–0.

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-36 — Brown Street Culvert Engineering Design [48:14]

Found on page 105 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Authorizes $21,500 to Sebago Technics to update a 2015 culvert-reconstruction design (near the Cottage Place Pump Station end of Brown Street) to current stream-crossing standards, after an earlier state grant-funding bid for the project was unsuccessful; the updated design is intended to support a future funding application.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed first reading, unanimous roll call, 7–0.

Action Items

None.

Closing

Public Comment (Second) & Adjournment [51:26]

Discussion Summary

No further public comment. No referrals, no committee reports, no executive session.

Key Decisions

✓ Motion to adjourn approved by unanimous roll call, 7–0.

Action Items

None.

How this was made

This summary was produced from the meeting video (linked above, hosted on the City's Vimeo showcase). The audio was downloaded with Downie 4 and transcribed with speaker diarization using MacWhisper. Claude (Anthropic's AI) cross-checked names and figures against the official packet and the city council roster, attributed speakers from context (introductions, roll-call order, direct address by the presiding officer) rather than the raw diarization labels alone, and drafted this summary and the quoted excerpts. Quotes are lightly cleaned of filler words/false starts but not reworded. Review tier: Not reviewed.

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